ERA 4

The American Revolution

1775 – 1783

Independence · the Revolutionary War · revolutionary ideals

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did the colonies win independence — and how far did revolutionary ideals of liberty actually extend?

KEY TERMS

Lexington & Concord · Declaration of Independence · Saratoga · French alliance · republican motherhood

ALIGNED TO

CED Topics 3.5–3.6 · AMSCO Ch. 3.5–3.6

SECTION

The War Begins

Lexington & Concord, 1775



- British troops marched to seize colonial weapons; **Paul Revere** spread the alarm.
- At dawn, a shot rang out—the **"shot heard round the world."**
- Colonial **minutemen** harried the redcoats back to Boston. The war had begun.

The Battle of Bunker Hill

- In June 1775, colonists inflicted heavy losses before retreating.
- It proved the **Patriots** would stand and fight.
- A costly British 'victory' that emboldened the rebellion.



SECTION

Declaring Independence

Toward Independence

Apr 1775
Lexington
Fighting begins in Massachusetts.

May 1775
2nd Congress
Washington named commander-in-chief.

Jan 1776
Common Sense
Paine's pamphlet swings opinion.

Jul 1776
Declaration
Independence is declared.

July 4, 1776

The Declaration of Independence

- Written mainly by **Thomas Jefferson** and adopted on July 4, 1776.
- It grounded independence in **natural rights**—'life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness.'
- It transformed a rebellion into the birth of a nation.



SECTION

Winning the War

The Turning Point: Saratoga



- In 1777 the Americans forced a British army to surrender at **Saratoga**.
- The victory convinced **France** the Americans could win.
- A formal **French alliance** brought money, troops, and a navy.

Who Fought, and Why

Patriots

~40% of colonists

- Wanted full **independence** from Britain.
- Farmers, artisans, and many elites.
- Fought for liberty and self-government.

Loyalists

~20–25% of colonists

- Stayed loyal to the British crown.
- Royal officials, some merchants and clergy.
- Feared disorder and mob rule.

A War of Many Peoples

- About 9,000 **Black Americans** fought for the Patriot cause.
- Most **Native** nations sided with Britain, fearing colonial expansion.
- Women ran farms and businesses and supplied the troops.



SECTION

The Revolution's Legacy

Liberty's Uneven Promise

"All men are created equal"—for whom?

GROUP	WHAT CHANGED	WHAT DIDN'T
Enslaved people	Northern states began **gradual emancipation**	Slavery entrenched in the South
Women	**Republican Motherhood**; more education	No vote; wives had no legal rights
Native Americans	(mostly allied with Britain)	Lost land as the U.S. expanded west

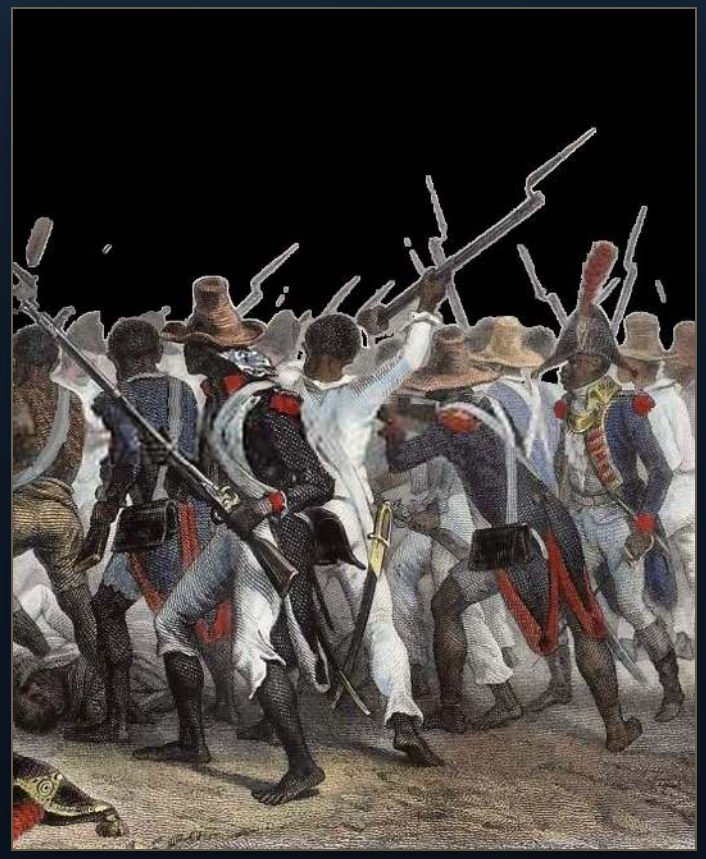
Republican Motherhood



- A new ideal: women would raise virtuous, liberty-minded citizens.
- It justified expanding education for women—modestly.
- But it kept women's role centered in the home.

A Revolution Heard Around the World

- American ideals helped inspire the **French Revolution** (1789).
- The **Haitian Revolution** turned those ideals against slavery itself.
- Latin American independence movements echoed the Declaration.



KEY TAKEAWAYS

The American Revolution

1. Fighting began at **Lexington & Concord (1775)**; the **Declaration of Independence (1776)** made it a bid for nationhood.

2. **Saratoga (1777)** secured the decisive **French alliance**; despite Loyalist opposition, the **Patriots** prevailed.

3. Revolutionary ideals had **uneven effects**—inspiring emancipation and revolutions abroad, while slavery and women's inequality endured.

DISCUSS & APPLY

The American Revolution

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

ARGUMENTATION

Using evidence about **enslaved people, women, and Native Americans**, argue how fully the Revolution lived up to "all men are created equal."

CAUSATION

Explain why **Saratoga** — not Lexington or Yorktown — is often called the decisive turning point of the war.

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

How did revolutionary ideals of liberty **change** society for some groups while leaving others unchanged?

Up next — **Lesson 8: A New Government** (Articles of Confederation & the Constitution)